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Splitting Religion: Heteronomy, Autonomy, and Reflection

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Cornelius Castoriadis, who was born in Greece but worked mainly in France, was a practicing psychoanalyst, cultural and political theorist, and philosopher. Recently, Castoriadis' work has been enjoying some wider recognition, and much of it has been translated into English in the past decade. Castoriadis has developed some seminal inquiries into the inter-relations of subjectivity and culture, focusing specifically on issues of heteronomy and autonomy. In the course of these inquiries, which in my view are themselves highly relevant for contemporary religious reflection, Castoriadis formulates some pointed *critical* arguments concerning the status of religion in relation to these issues. There have also been several other thinkers emerging on the French scene in the past fifteen years or so, quite different in style and background from Castoriadis, who share some of his core concerns with the over-riding issues of autonomy and heteronomy in the relations between individual and society. Here, I will mainly draw upon some ideas of Marcel Gauchet, whose notion of a 'split' within religion will be used to develop a critical augmentation of Castoriadis' arguments concerning religion and heteronomy.

Notes

James J. DiCenso received his Ph.D. in Religion from Syracuse University in 1987, and has taught there, at Oberlin College, at Memorial University of Newfoundland, and is currently Associate Professor of Religion at the University of Toronto. DiCenso specializes in modern and contemporary thought, especially in the psychoanalytic and Continental philosophy traditions, and its application to religious issues. DiCenso's work has been consistent in exploring the possibilities of re-interpreting religion as related to current concerns with ethics, meaning and orientation on the personal and cultural levels. He is the author of two books: *Hermeneutics and the Disclosure of Truth: A Study in the Work of Heidegger, Gadamer, and Ricoeur* (University of Virginia Press, 1990), and *The Other Freud: Religion, Culture and Psychoanalysis* (Routledge, 1999). He has also published numerous articles on the intersections between religion and philosophy in Derrida, Lacan, Kristeva, and others. He is currently working on a third book analyzing religion in relation to ethical and socio-political issues, focussing on resources for actualizing justice, freedom, and human rights.

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